Russia Frees American Teacher Stephen Hubbard

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Russian President Vladimir Putin says he has freed Stephen Hubbard, a 74-year-old American, from a Russian prison after a request from President Trump.

Hubbard is a former school teacher from Michigan. Russian forces detained him in eastern Ukraine in 2022. In 2024, after a **closed trial**, a Russian court sentenced him to nearly seven years in prison. Russia accused him of serving as a paid fighter in Ukraine's army. The United States had officially said he was **wrongfully detained**.

The news came as Putin met with Steve Witkoff, a White House **envoy**, in the Russian city of Saint Petersburg. Their talks focused on a new U.S. plan to end the war in Ukraine. Witkoff thanked Putin for arranging the release, and Putin said Hubbard was already at the airport, waiting to leave Russia.

President Trump celebrated on social media. "Welcome home Stephen, it's great to have you back," he wrote. He said the U.S. had not given anything in return, so there was no prisoner "swap."

Hubbard's son also thanked both leaders. He said the family had been worried about his father's safety and health since 2022.

Not everyone was pleased with how the meeting went. Witkoff called Putin "a **humanitarian**," which angered many Ukrainians. They see Putin as the leader responsible for Russia's war on their country. A Ukrainian lawmaker said Witkoff should not represent the United States.

A **Kremlin** aide later said Putin had agreed to restart peace talks with the U.S. and Ukraine in mid-November. For now, Hubbard's family is simply glad he is coming home.

Word Treasure

envoy -- An envoy is a person sent by a government to deliver messages or hold talks for it.

wrongfully detained -- Being wrongfully detained means being held by a government without a fair reason.

humanitarian -- A humanitarian is someone who works to help people and reduce suffering.

Kremlin -- The Kremlin is the seat of Russia's government in Moscow, and the word is often used to mean Russia's leaders.

closed trial -- A closed trial is a court case that the public and reporters are not allowed to watch.

Background you need

Russia launched a full-scale war on its neighbor Ukraine in 2022, and the fighting has continued since then.

When a country holds a foreign citizen in prison, that person's home government often works through diplomats and envoys to try to bring them home.

Sometimes such releases happen through a prisoner swap, where each country frees someone, but in this case the U.S. says it gave nothing in return.

The United States has been trying to bring Russia and Ukraine together for peace talks to end the war.

Break it down

LEAD: Putin says Russia freed American Stephen Hubbard after President Trump's request
KEY EVENT: Hubbard released as Putin meets White House envoy Steve Witkoff
+- WHO: Stephen Hubbard, 74, a former teacher from Michigan
+- WHERE: Saint Petersburg, Russia
+- BACKGROUND: detained in eastern Ukraine in 2022, sentenced in 2024 to nearly seven years
REACTIONS: Trump welcomes him home and says there was no swap; Hubbard's son thanks both leaders
CONTROVERSY: Witkoff calls Putin a humanitarian, angering Ukrainians
WHAT NEXT: Kremlin aide says three-way peace talks could restart in mid-November

Why it matters

The release shows how personal cases can become part of big talks between countries, and it came as the U.S. pushes for peace talks to end the war in Ukraine.

Test what you remember

1. How old is Stephen Hubbard?

- (A) 47
- (B) 74
- (C) 84
- (D) 64

2. What was Hubbard's job before he was detained?

- (A) Soldier
- (B) Doctor
- (C) School teacher
- (D) Reporter

3. Which U.S. state is Hubbard from?

- (A) California
- (B) Ohio
- (C) Michigan
- (D) Texas

4. Where did Putin meet White House envoy Steve Witkoff?

- (A) Moscow
- (B) Kyiv
- (C) Washington
- (D) Saint Petersburg

5. What did President Trump say the U.S. gave Russia in return?

- (A) A Russian prisoner
- (B) Money
- (C) Nothing
- (D) Oil

6. Why were many Ukrainians angry?

- (A) Peace talks were canceled
- (B) Witkoff called Putin a humanitarian
- (C) Trump visited Russia
- (D) Hubbard refused to leave

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: D 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. President Trump: Celebrated the release and said the U.S. gave nothing in return, so there was no swap.
2. Hubbard's family: His son thanked both leaders and said the family had worried about his safety and health since 2022.
3. Ukrainians: Many were angered that Witkoff called Putin a humanitarian; a Ukrainian lawmaker said Witkoff should not represent the U.S.
4. The U.S. government: Had officially said Hubbard was wrongfully detained.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):